It took me some time to understand the different perspectives. The first and foremost issue I realized, was that of payment. The ARPAN programme was to be rolled out over forty-five Record Offices pan-India, the responsibility of which lay with the Army, and would take a few years. Tech Mahindra felt that their responsibility was to develop the software and once proven through test-bedding and acceptance trials, they should be paid in full. This was a fair argument because they had no say in the roll-out, which could take years. As it is they had already invested two years in this project and not seen a single rupee in return. We discussed the matter with the IFA who also saw that there was indeed a flaw in the way the contract was worded. He agreed that we could go in for phase-wise payments based on quantifiable milestones in terms of the number of Record Offices automated. Since the programme had already been test-bedded in seven ROs, the proportionate payment could be made to them straight away, and the same principle applied in the future without having to refer to him again. This was a big breakthrough: Tech Mahindra got some infusion of funds with a clear road map for future payments, yet we too retained control. It was a win-win solution. Thus enthused, and with their confidence restored, we could amicably resolve the rest of the issues. The ARPAN 3.0 version was launched live by the then Defence Minister, Shri Manohar Parrikar, in July 2015, coinciding with the National Digital India Week, which had been launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. This was one of the success stories of the DGIS, but the real credit should go to the IFA, who interpreted the DPM and DFPDS in a pragmatic manner to get the job done.

In April, the Army Commanders' Conference was held and along with that, our Special Selection Board (SSB) for promotion to the rank of Lt Gen. The recommendations of the

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